



ANEK DHAR,
the 18-year-old
participant on *Ek Se
Badhkar Ek*, snatches
a yawn during his
15-hour shoot

actress. For the past three months, she's been living in TV Central, Oshiwara, participating in 9X's latest reality show, *Chak De Bachche*, which costs over Rs 50 lakh an episode. She, like the other 10 participants in the show, who live three to a room in a flat the channel has rented for them, wakes up at 5.30 a.m. every day. Today, she's spent an-hour-and-a-half in the vanity room getting her hair and make-up done, been fussed over for 20 minutes about a wound on her ankle and how she would now not be able to wear her shiny silver heels that match her equally shiny black and silver velvet dress. But as soon as the camera inches towards her, the pain from the wound vanishes, only to be replaced by fluttering eyes and coy glances.

It wasn't always so, says Ravi Behl, one of the three founders of *Boogie Woogie*. They started the show at a time when there was no platform for dancers and says even now, "we correct the parents when the kids are given adult songs and adult moves to perform." But being in the limelight has its compensations, he says, giving the example of Jai Nayar and Hrishikesh Jogdan, both teenagers, who were

selected to be part of the Mithun Chakraborty-starrer *Fast Forward* after the actor visited the sets as a celebrity judge. Apart from that, of course, there is a hefty cash prize of up to Rs 5 lakh and a car, or Rs 10 lakh to lap up, depending on the season and the age of performers.

But watch a shoot of *Chak De Bachche* closely, and it is easy to mistake the finalists for their adult celebrity counterparts, who dance, bitch, thank the audience, touch the judges' feet and demand votes with equal gusto. Eight-year-old Amaan Khan recites couplets that his mother teaches him on the phone from Indore; Rudraksh Agarwal from Jaipur, only a year older, exudes a Buddha-like calm and has advice for the audience and anchors every time the mike is shoved in his face for an on-stage

response. Just like scores of other kids who're taken to auditions by the parents, it was Agarwal's homemaker mother who chanced upon the ad-

vertisement for the show and along with her husband, who owns a sari showroom, decided that her young son had the talent. He has been learning singing for the past three years, and now the veteran of *Star Voice of India Chhote Ustad* says with confidence: "When I grow up, I'll show the world my full talent." His school, Sawai Mansingh Vidyalaya, judged him on his earlier two terms and promoted him.

If television is forcing these kids to lose their childhood, no one seems to care. Take Sanchita Bhattacharya, all of 14 when she won *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Li'l Champs* in 2006. Her life has changed, as has her parents'. Her 53-year-old father, Dhrubo Bhattacharya, a clerk with Howrah Corporation for 18 years, was a music teacher and an artiste as well at the All India Radio and Kolkata Doordarshan. He has now taken

overs and handles her shows, as also her film assignments.

"Sanchita does complain that she can't lead a normal life because instead of going to

The children want to emulate
Britney Spears
but are unaware of
her troubled present.